

AN ANCIENT LAND

Australia and New Zealand

The smallest continent, Australia is surrounded by water and sits in the middle of the huge Australian Plate. This plate is largely inundated by the Pacific and Indian Oceans but is dotted with islands—some large like New Guinea, others tiny like the Fijian islands. New Zealand straddles the boundary between the Australian and adjacent Pacific Plates.

Australia is dominated by the vast and flat outback, scorched by the tropical sun. In the east, it rises to the Great Dividing Range of mountains, and beyond lies the moist and mild coastal plain. Off the northeast coast stretches the world's biggest coral reef, the Great Barrier Reef. Temperate New Zealand's two islands lie far to the east—a mix of lofty, snowcapped mountains, rolling plains, and active volcanic features.

